

throughout your browsing experience. In case you're not happy with the look, Opera Mini does allow a choice of different skins.

At the top of the screen is a URL address bar, below which is a search bar (set to Google by default, but you can customise it), followed by a Bookmarks pane – simple features that make navigation just so easy.

Visit a web page of your liking and the first thing to strike you will be how much it looks like the desktop equivalent.

Before going further into the user experience, we would like to digress just a little. The best feature of Opera Mini for us Indians is how well it handles data usage. Internet plans from cellular services are quite expensive here, with a lot of users opting for pay-by-usage schemes. Here is where Opera shines.

For starters, it uses an amazing compression engine to render Web pages for mobile phone viewing. What this means is that when you visit a page, it first sends all its data to one of Opera's servers. The server analyses and compresses this page before sending it to your phone. Not only does this save a lot of data costs, but also increases speed exponentially. According to Opera, a BBC page of 270KB that took 33 seconds to load now opens in 15 seconds at just 40KB!

The other feature that's gone a long way in speeding up browsing and cutting down costs is the cache. Hitting 'Back' is one of the most common activities in surfing; but mobile browsers used to reload the page each time. Opera Mini fixed this problem by caching the pages during your current session.

Now, back to the navigation. So you open up a page and the desktop-like layout greets you. For non-touchscreen phones,



Opera Mini offers a mouse feature that can be used to pan across a web page and zoom into a column of text